Aquifer Open Study Notes (Profiles)

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C

Caleb

Caleb is an inspiring example of faith in God. He was the son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite (Joshua 14:6; Numbers 32:12). The Kenizzites lived in the Negev, the southern desert region of Canaan (see Genesis 15:18–21). Jephunneh likely married into the tribe of Judah a generation before Israel left Egypt.

Caleb first appears as one of the twelve spies Moses sent to explore the land of Canaan. Upon returning, all twelve confirmed the land was impressive, but ten of the scouts focused on its fearsome residents (Numbers 13:31–33). Only Joshua and Caleb believed that God would help Israel conquer the Canaanites (Numbers 14:6–9), advising the Israelites to take the land immediately (Numbers 13:30).

The people wanted to stone Caleb and Joshua (Numbers 14:10). But God protected them and punished the people (Numbers 14:11–38). God ultimately rewarded Caleb and Joshua for their faithfulness: Among all the adults who left Egypt, they were the only ones to enter the promised land.

After many years in the wilderness and fighting many battles, Caleb received his inheritance in the land (Joshua 14:6–15). Caleb's faith remained strong over forty-five years. His story shows his character and firm faith in God. Although Caleb was eighty-five years old, he was still strong and able to fight. Caleb took Hebron as his land by driving out the giant Anakites who had scared the earlier scouts (Joshua 15:13–14; see Numbers 13:28, 33).

Caleb lived in the city of Hebron, which was about twenty miles south of Jerusalem. This city was close to where the Kenizzite people lived. Later, Hebron became a special city where the Levites (priests) lived and where people could go for safety (Joshua 21:13; 1 Chronicles 6:54–57).

Caleb focused on God's promise that Israel would live in Canaan, despite serious obstacles. With full energy, he was ready to take the land Joshua gave him. Caleb's strong belief in God's promises made him respected among the faithful. Even when he was outnumbered by enemies, Caleb trusted God, and God rewarded him greatly.

Passages for Further Study

Numbers 13:1–14:38; 26:65; 32:12; 34:19; Deuteronomy 1:36; Joshua 14:6–15; 15:13–19; Judges 1:11–15, 20; 1 Chronicles 4:15

Corinth

Corinth is one of Greece's oldest cities, with settlements dating back to at least 3000 BC. Its strategic location on key trade routes helped it become a major center for commerce. Corinth reached its peak power between 800 and 600 BC. In the mid-100s BC, as the Roman military expanded its empire, Corinth led the Hellenic League to resist Roman control in Greece. However, they could not defeat the Romans. In 146 BC, the Romans completely destroyed Corinth, executing the men and selling the women and children into slavery. Corinth remained in ruins for a century.

In 44 BC, Julius Caesar founded a Roman colony in Corinth. This colony attracted a diverse group of Italians, freedmen (freed former slaves) from Rome, and displaced Greeks. The new residents, with hard work and creativity, quickly rebuilt the city into a thriving hub for trade, commerce, and industry. By the time Paul arrived in Corinth, it was a lively, diverse city with nearly 700,000 people, including many wealthy individuals and others aspiring to wealth.

Corinth drew tradespeople from around the world, but it also became known for luxury, indulgence, and vice. The city had a reputation for promiscuity and prostitution, so much so that the verb "Corinthianize" meant engaging in immoral sexual behavior. The church in Corinth experienced challenges with sexual immorality (1 Corinthians 5:1–13; 6:12–20).

Corinth was also important because of the Isthmian Games, which began in 523 BC and took place every two years. The events focused on three types: equestrian, gymnastic, and musical. By the New Testament period, the games included chariot racing and other Roman shows, along with traditional Greek competitions. Paul referred to these athletic contests, mentioning both running and boxing (1 Corinthians 9:24–26). The winners of the games became national heroes. They received a wreath made of myrtle, olive, or pine branches. They also got a stipend from the state, tax exemptions, and special benefits for their children.

In most Roman cities, marble temples dominated the landscape. Worshiping the gods and attending their feasts were important parts of life in Corinth. The Corinthian church struggled with these pagan feasts (1 Corinthians 8:1–10:33).

A large group of displaced Jews also settled in the city. Many may have arrived after Emperor Claudius expelled Jews from Rome (see Acts 18:2). When Paul traveled to Corinth on his second missionary journey, he met Aquila and Priscilla. They became his close

Cyrus II

friends and co-workers (Acts 18:1–3). Paul stayed in Corinth for over a year and a half, teaching the word of God (Acts 18:11).

The church of Corinth, emerging in a place full of paganism and promiscuity, experienced many challenges. Paul's letters to them offer valuable solutions to practical issues in Christian life and community.

Passages for Further Study

Acts 18:1–18; 1 Corinthians 1:1–2; 16:5–20; 2 Corinthians 1:1; 13:1; 2 Timothy 4:20

Cyrus II

Cyrus II, king of Persia from 559 to 530 BC, founded the Persian Empire. His father was the king of Persia, a small nation under Media's control, and his mother was the daughter of the king of the Medes. In 549 BC, Cyrus conquered the Medes and united the two nations. He then conquered Lydia in Asia Minor in 547 BC. Turning east, he added Parthia and part of India to the Persian Empire. Finally, on October 29, 539 BC, Cyrus conquered Babylon and included Babylonia in his empire (see Daniel 5:30–31).

After conquering Babylon, Cyrus issued a decree allowing the Jewish people to return home and rebuild the Temple in Jerusalem. The part of this decree concerning the Jews is recorded in 2 Chronicles 36:22–23 and Ezra 1:1–4. The Cyrus Cylinder, a barrel found in Babylon between 1879 and 1882, confirms this practice. It describes Cyrus's policy on conquered peoples.

Isaiah identified Cyrus as the future liberator of Judah (Isaiah 44:28–45:13). Isaiah referred to Cyrus as the Lord's anointed (Isaiah 45:1, Hebrew mashiakh, meaning "messiah"). Israel saw Cyrus as chosen and empowered by God to free them. Cyrus was not the Messiah, but his actions foreshadowed what the Messiah, Jesus Christ, would later do in freeing God's people from servitude.

Passages for Further Study

2 Chronicles 36:22–23; Ezra 1:1–11; 3:7; 4:1–5; 5:6–17; 6:14–15; Isaiah 44:28–45:13; 48:14–16; Daniel 6:28; 10:1